

NOW THAT THE world of glitz and glamour is measured outside of just a compelling script, the runway, or the turf, it is little wonder that some of India's most recognisable celebrities are stepping into the premium spirits business—not as endorsers, but as founders and investors.

The latest to raise a glass is actor Vivek Oberoi, who recently acquired a 21% stake in Rutland Square Spirits, a Scotland-based house known for its oolong white tea-infused gin. This is not a trend unique to India.

Globally, celebrity-backed spirits have been around for a while with big names like George Clooney, Dwayne Jhonson, Ryan Reynolds, and Kylie Jenner leading the trend. According to International Wine and Spirits Research, celebrity whiskies grew 8% by volume in 2023, compared with 2% growth for whisky overall. Celebrity rums expanded 11% in a category that declined 4%. Tequila has proved particularly magnetic: in 2022, celebrity tequilas surged 4%, far outpacing the broader category.

Tequila's renaissance has coincided with a generation of younger drinkers who are curious and socially networked. They are comfortable discovering brands on Instagram but increasingly expect substance behind the styling.

TEQUILA SUNRISE

"Tequila has quietly become one of the fastest-growing premium spirits globally," says actor and film producer Rana Daggubati who, along



1. & 2. Aryan Khan has launched his own brand of spirits—D'YAVOL—that includes a single estate vodka and two whiskies

with musician/composer Anirudh Ravichander, has launched Loka Loka tequila in association with Hyderabad-based entrepreneur Harsha Vadlamudi, Managing Partner of Ironhill India. The global market, he notes, already exceeds \$20 billion and is projected to expand significantly. In India, agave-based spirits grew roughly 36% by volume in 2024, he says.

So, what made him become a

co-founder and not just endorse the brand? "It moved beyond endorsement when the conversation shifted from visibility to viability. Once I saw the rigour behind the plan that spanned market sizing, category growth curves, agave supply dynamics, regulatory mapping, and a clear route to scale, the decision moved firmly into the strategic territory," says the actor known for his role in films such